desolate areas beyond the purview of clearly demarcated pedestrian footpaths, these signs continue to evoke something elusive and ghostly about the American presence in Berlin. While neither subject nor fully subtext of the artist's explorations of the city, they comprise a landmark in reference to the long arc of U.S. military intervention and occupation. If the signs are both explicit and redundant with the walls behind them, do they attest to military strength, a competing claim of sovereignty, or a woebegone claim to American power over this geopolitical space? Are these signs functional or obsolete relics? Tajiri does not offer a clear answer. Like his knots, they give the appearance of completeness without an anchor or clear functionality. In the early years of Berlin's division, the signs may have made sense as a means to demarcate the landscape, but in the years of a maturing border system, Tajiri picks up on their enduring, odd placements. They have become a part of the scenery as border structures have been built despite them and flora has grown around them.

Tajiri's compositions in the center of the city focus less on the negative spaces around the Wall and more on the death strip area and construction zone of the borderline. He views materials that sit close to the Wall that are left in the temporarily deactivated death strips and the machinery once aimed to reinforce the border but now in a state of disuse. Instances of heightened activity and architectural makeover are visible as the circumstances of a renovation in progress, alongside others of disrepair and disregard. West Berliners are seen nonchalantly gathering, playing, or moving through the city, all near the Wall. For example, one man, whom Tajiri captures in several frames, walks his dog and peeks through a gap in a newly placed concrete barrier to view the construction activity on the other side. Within several blocks, at the intersection of Zimmerstrasse and Lindenstrasse, Tajiri finds a Wall area nearly finished in its reconstruction (fig. 3.5). At least five strata of the border systems past and present can be seen here, from wire fencing around the border's guard post to the tank traps in the death strip to an updated interior "hinter" wall to the elements of a new outer wall nearly raised to include new concrete slabs. But from his view, Tajiri focuses on traces of the previous generation of wall building and a sandy area in the foreground with a parked excavator with no workers in sight. Two American sector signs are visible: one has been ungrounded and lies atop a pile of building materials, while another, beyond the sandy construction zone, is still upright. The presumption, if one follows the rest of the strange logic of